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Author(s): Melissa Choloniuk and Martin Beckmann

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The Temple of Janus and the Neronian *Sestertius* Issue of 64/5 CE

Melissa Choloniuk* and Martin Beckmann**

This die study of a single yearly issue of Neronian *sestertii* sheds light on the employment of coin types in the Roman mint and on the earliest appearance of the Temple of Janus on Nero's coinage.[1]

INTRODUCTION

This study presents a die analysis of *sestertii* of Nero struck at Rome in MacDowall's Issue IV, datable to the year 64/5 CE by the inclusion of a single obverse die bearing TR POT XI.[2] The goal of this study is to understand the sequence of production of the different *sestertius* reverse types, their relative volume of production by estimated die counts, and to attempt to identify the earliest dies in the issue. This allows us to draw conclusions about the conception of the issue's typology and its development over the duration of production. It also allows investigation of the most noteworthy novel type of the issue, the Temple of Janus, in light of Kleiner's study of another Neronian architectural type, the Arch of Nero.

Nero's *aes* Issue IV at Rome is distinguished from the one that precedes it by an entirely new (and much more restricted) type repertoire and by a change in

* Queen's University (15mmc3@queensu.ca).
** McMaster University (beckmam@mcmaster.ca).

1. M. Choloniuk conducted the die analysis; both authors collaborated on the writing of this article.

2. MacDowall 1979, 75 (for a summary of issues) and 77–78; Sutherland 1984, 140–1.

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the alloys of the *aes* denominations, from the short-lived all-*orichalcum* in Issues II and III back to the traditional system of *orichalcum sestertii* and *dupondii* with copper *asses* and *quadrantes* in Issue IV. Issue IV is distinguished from the succeeding issues by the use of IMP as a cognomen, instead of its use as a praenomen in the later issues. Issue IV represents a substantial narrowing of the typology of the base-metal coinage. The previous issue had included the following types: (in *sestertii*) Adlocutio, Decursio, Anonna, Congiarium, the Arch of Nero, and the Harbor of Ostia; (in *dupondii*) Nero's Macellum, Victoria, and Securitas; and (on *asses*) Apollo and Genius. In 64/5 CE, the type repertoire was reduced to the Temple of Janus (facing either right or left) and Roma (in three minor variations); these are the only types used on the *sestertii* and *dupondii* in this issue, and the *asses* add only the type of Victoria (while not employing Roma). An ideological shift, or a modification of the message of the coinage, appears to be intended. The earlier types of the *aes* were focused on honorific themes (e.g., the Arch and Decursio) and on acts or policies of Nero that benefited the urban populace in a concrete way (e.g., Anonna, Harbor, Congiarium, and Macellum). Now these are replaced by a much more limited repertoire, in essence two types only: Roma, a depiction of the city personified; and the Temple of Janus, a building of more symbolic than practical relevance to the inhabitants of the capital, and not one built by Nero but instead associated with a limited but highly symbolic act of the emperor, the importance of which is underlined by the rare inscription describing the emperor's action: PACE P R TERRA MARIQ PARTA IANVM CLVSIT, "after having obtained peace for the Roman people on both land and sea, he closed the Temple of Janus."

Die Analysis of Nero's Issue IV *Sestertii*

The die analysis focuses exclusively on the *sestertii* struck at Rome, rather than those produced at Lugdunum (the products of Lugdunum are distinguished by a globe beneath the bust).[3] A corpus of 440 *sestertii* of Issue IV was assembled from the Online Coins of the Roman Empire (OCRE) database (https://numismatics.org/ocre/), which includes the holdings of many of the most important public collections worldwide, and from CoinArchives.com. These *sestertii* were struck by 230 obverse dies and 288 reverse dies. The die counts of obverse types observed in the study are as follows:

3. For the identification of these issues, see MacDowall 1979, 15–24, and Sutherland and Carson 1984, 136–37.

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	Obverse inscription and type	Dies observed
a	NERO CAESAR AVG IMP TR POT XI PPP Nero, right, laureate, cuirassed.	1
b	NERO CLAVD CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP Nero, right, laureate, sometimes with aegis	106
c	NERO CLAVD CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP Nero, left, laureate	53
d	NERO CLAVDIVS CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP Nero, right, laureate, sometimes with aegis	51
e	NERO CLAVDIVS CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP Nero, left, laureate	19

The two broad categories of reverse type, the Temple of Janus and Roma seated holding Victory, can be subdivided depending on the direction the temple faces and on the supplementary object held by Roma. The temple exists in two main versions, door facing right (as seen by the viewer) and door facing left. The type of Roma (seated holding Victory on her outstretched hand) exists in three versions, depending on what she is holding in the other hand: a *parazonium*, a shield, or a spear. The following chart gives the dies observed in the study, in addition to a die estimate and estimated coverage of the sample, according to Esty's geometric model.[4] The coverage is "the number of coins in the original population struck by dies in the sample" divided by "the total number of coins struck by all the dies."[5]

	Reverse types	Coins	Dies observed	Dies estimated	Coverage estimated
F	Temple of Janus, door right	127	91	321	0.425
G	Temple of Janus, door left	39	21	46	0.692

4. Esty 2011. The die estimate according to the geometric model is $(nd)/(n-d)$, where n is the number of coins and d the number of dies observed. The coverage is estimated using $1-(d_1/n)$, where d_1 is the number of dies observed exactly once. The data (n, d, d_1) for the types are: F 127, 91, 73; G 39, 21, 12; H 243, 157, 104; J 13, 5, 2; K 18, 14, 11. For type F, for example, the calculation of the die estimate is $(127\times91)/(127-91)=11{,}557/36=321$, while the calculation of the coverage estimate is $1-(73/127)=1-0.575=0.425$.

5. Esty 2011, 49.

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	Reverse types	Coins	Dies observed	Dies estimated	Coverage estimated
H	Roma, holding Victory and *parazonium*	243	157	443	0.572
J	Roma, holding Victory and shield	13	5	8	0.846
K	Roma, holding Victory and spear	18	14	63	0.388

From these results, it is immediately apparent that Temple of Janus right (F) and Roma with Victory and *parazonium* (H) are by far the two most common types of their categories. This raises the question of why each main type-category (Temple and Roma) appears to have a "main type" that dominates the die count and a variant or variants that appear on smaller numbers of dies. The die links point to an explanation for this, one that sheds light on how the mint operated with respect to the deployment of coin types both at the beginning of this new type "cycle" and how type usage in the mint changed over the course of the production of coins with a specific group of types.

PATTERN OF DIE LINKS

Given the relatively low ratio of coins to dies observed in this study, we might not expect any large die chains. This is generally true, although there are some notable exceptions. If *sestertius* production had been constant, using a consistent number of dies at any given time throughout the year, we might expect to find some scattered small groups of linked dies. If the different reverse types had been spread evenly through this year-long production, we might expect to find them distributed through these groupings. But this is not what was found. Most links, as expected, are isolated obverse-reverse pairs, most of these represented by single coins. Larger clusters of linked reverse dies tend to be either single types or combinations of the two most common types, F (temple right) and H (Roma with *parazonium*). In this context, we might expect to find the rare Roma types J (with shield, 5 dies) and K (with spear, 14 dies) mainly as isolated obverse-reverse pairs, with a few scattered through the larger die clusters. But instead, more than half (3 of 5) of the J dies and almost half (6 of 14) of the K dies are all linked together in a single large die cluster (fig. 1) with two F (temple right) and five H (Roma with *parazonium*) dies. Notably, this large cluster contains no G (temple left) dies.

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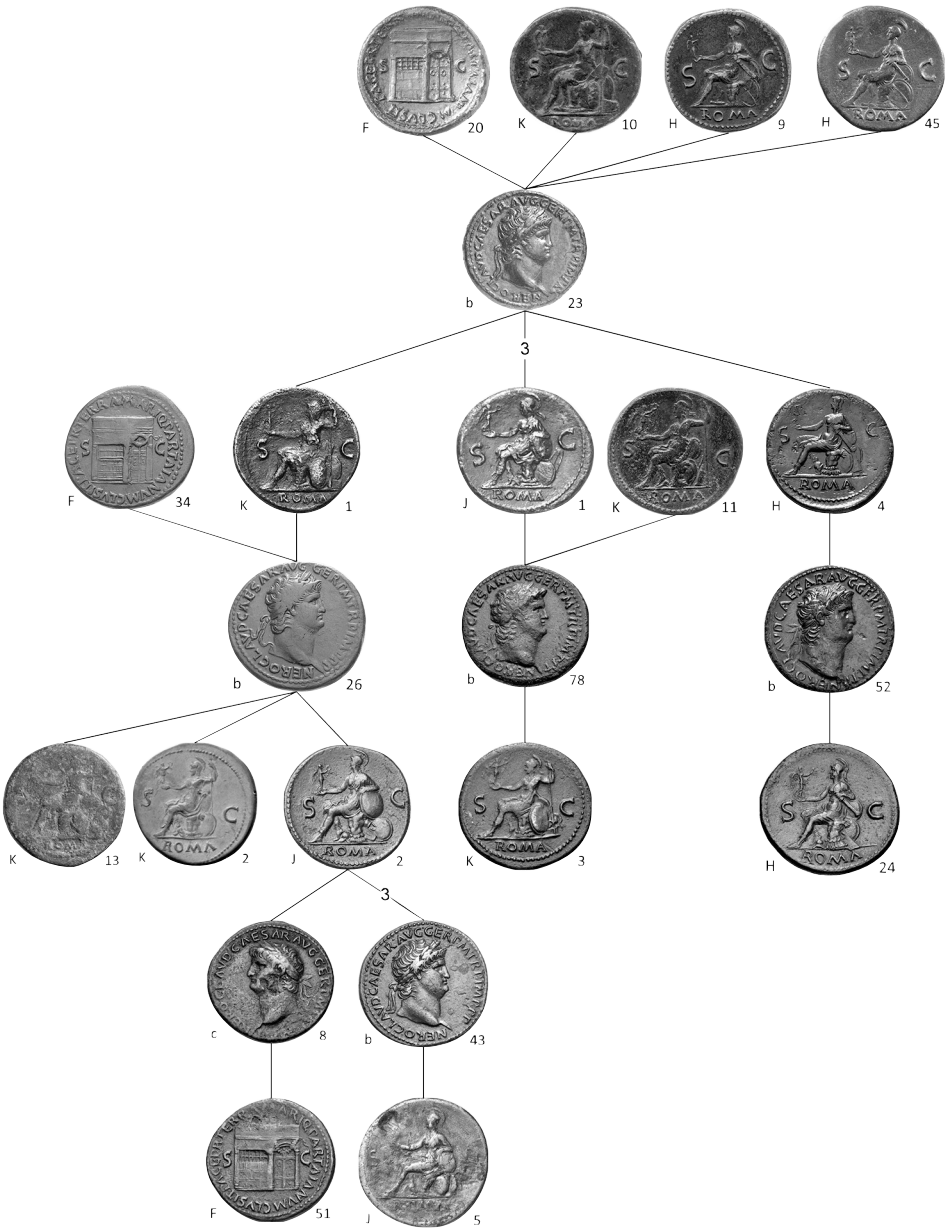


Figure 1. Largest and probably earliest die cluster of Nero's Issue IV *sestertii*, containing all types except G (temple left).

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Our interpretation of this pattern of die links is that the Roman mint began production of Nero's Issue IV *sestertii* with four types: Temple of Janus (facing right) and Roma with its three main variants, holding either *parazonium*, shield, or spear. Dies bearing each of these types were cut and employed together in the mint for a short period of time early in the life of this issue (so, in late 64). Relatively soon, however, perhaps early in 65 CE, dies with two of the Roma variants (with shield and with spear) ceased being cut, and from that time onward only Roma with *parazonium* (H) dies were cut in the mint. This may have been the result of a conscious decision made for the sake of streamlining production, perhaps based on a single model being selected for all Roma dies, or it may have been the result of an oversight by die engravers who overlooked the intended variety in Roma's original attributes and instead went on to produce only one of the three original variants. This pattern of links also suggests that Temple of Janus facing left may not have been part of the original repertoire of types of the issue, although the fact that one die of this type (G15) does link to one of the rare Roma variants (K5) in a small die cluster with one F and one H die cautions against this interpretation.[6]

MacDowall proposed that in Nero's mint, reverse types would have served to distinguish *officinae*, which he defined as subdivisions of the mint, intended both to spread out the work of minting and to facilitate control of the coins produced by each unit.[7] According to this theory, most of the time there were two *officinae* for each denomination, corresponding to the two types most often used in each issue. Regarding the variations of types such as the spear, shield, or *parazonium* held by Roma in Issue IV, MacDowall was inclined to see these as variations internal to the *officina* and not as markers of further *officinae*.[8] An *officina* system certainly did exist in the later third century, when its divisions are indicated by marks on the coinage, but arguments for its existence in earlier periods are dependent on scarce die-link evidence. The *aurei* of Trajan in 112 CE show evidence of the existence of two parallel *officinae*, which were distinguished by

6. Similarly, a link recorded by MacDowall (1979, 256) also suggests that the temple left type might be an early development. This is a die link between a Temple of Janus with door left reverse and three Decursio dies of Issue III, via a common obverse die (of type d from this study); MacDowall gives a reference to "Hirsch 12, 463." We have not seen this coin. This link, if confirmed, may connect the two issues and, if so, it would be further evidence against the suggestion that the door left version of the temple type is a later development. The potential of linkage between Issues III and IV deserves further investigation.

7. MacDowall 1979, 118, for reverse types as indicators of *officinae* in the *aes* coinage, and 111 for the definition of these units and their function.

8. MacDowall 1979, 119.

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both case used on the obverse die (dative or nominative) and by the types of reverse die used (architectural types connected to Trajan's Forum in one line of production, types depicting Trajan's adoptive and natural fathers in the other).[9] Gold coinage of Faustina the Younger struck in the 150s and 160s shows, at different times, three different systems of die use: a single linear chain, two parallel chains distinguished by different obverse and reverse types, and at one point a densely interlinked group of dies without a clear chronological direction.[10]

The die analysis presented here does not appear to support MacDowall's theory of the existence of distinct *officinae* in Nero's mint to produce this issue of *sestertii*. The two main types, Roma and Temple of Janus, are regularly and consistently linked, both in the early phase of production illustrated in figure 1 and in all subsequent production. MacDowall argued that die sharing between *officinae* was possible and offered some documented examples from later periods.[11] But it is difficult to understand how so many links between the Roma and the Temple of Janus types came to be, unless these dies were employed alongside each other in a single production sequence, a procedure that would appear to make the different reverse dies unsuitable for control of production. The minting of Issue IV *sestertii* may well have employed multiple anvils at the same time, but there is no clear indication that production was ever segregated by reverse type in an *officina* system. Instead, the apparent rough equation between the total estimated die counts suggests that there was an intention to produce coinage marked by two distinct types, and that coins bearing these types should be produced roughly in balance. Ideological or communicative reasons may lie behind this intention. Furthermore, the disappearance of two of the three Roma variants further indicates that it was the main theme (Roma) that was important for this type, rather than its variations. It is not clear why these variations were introduced in the first place.

THE TEMPLE OF JANUS

This study of Nero's Issue IV *sestertii* also offers an opportunity to investigate the representation of the Temple of Janus, the only ancient depiction of this lost building. The Temple of Janus was rectangular but lacked the normal portico of a Roman temple; it was described by Procopius, who visited Rome around 535 CE:

9. See Beckmann 2007.

10. On die links in the gold coinage of Faustina, see Beckmann 2021, 15–16 (in general), 25 (linear chain), 43 (densely interlinked dies) and 52 (two parallel chains).

11. Beckmann 2021, 112.

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> And the temple is entirely of bronze and was erected in the form of a square, but it is only large enough to cover the statue of Janus. Now this statue is of bronze, and not less than five cubits high; in all other respects it resembles a man, but its head has two faces, one of which is turned toward the east and the other toward the west. And there are brazen doors fronting each face, which the Romans in olden times were accustomed to close in time of peace and prosperity, but when they had war they opened them.[12]

Augustus claimed to have closed the doors to the temple three times; later, it was closed once more by Nero after his defeat of the Parthians.[13]

Representations of buildings on the Roman coinage are important for two reasons.[14] One is the evidence they provide for broader changes in Roman society, culture, and politics.[15] Aristocratic competition in the time of the republic motivated moneyers to depict monuments that had been erected by their ancestors on their coinage, whereas during the empire, emphasis tended to shift to newly constructed buildings that reflected the priorities of the ruling emperor. The second and more problematic importance of architectural types on Roman coinage is their debatable role as evidence for the original appearance of ancient buildings, especially those for which little or no other evidence exists. The study of such representations even received its own Latin neologism in the nineteenth century: *architectura numismatica*, from the title of an influential book by T. L. Donaldson.[16] Fuchs stressed the necessity of not taking the image of a building on a coin at face value as evidence for its appearance: "[j]edes Münzbild ist unzuverlässig" (every coin image is unreliable).[17] Each building type must be considered individually, Fuchs argued, and no general rules can be established for determining the value of a building image for the reconstruction of that building.[18]

The most detailed individual study of the image of a particular building depicted on a Roman coin is Kleiner's study of representations of the Arch of Nero on that emperor's *sestertii*.[19] This marked a significant methodological step forward in this field: Kleiner theorized that among all the coins depicting the

12. Procopius, *History of the Wars* 5.25. Translated by H. B. Dewing.
13. Livy, *History of Rome* 1.19; Suetonius, *Augustus* 22; Suetonius, *Nero* 6.13.
14. For a recent survey of approaches to these coin types, see Elkins 2015, 2–7.
15. Elkins 2015, especially 9–13 and 167–70.
16. Donaldson 1859.
17. Fuchs 1969, 119.
18. See, in general, Fuchs 1969, 116–29.
19. Kleiner 1985.

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arch, it was the earliest dies, and those from Rome (rather than Lugdunum), that would provide the most accurate representations of the building. This idea was based on the theory that these dies would have been made directly from a sketch or model of the original building, while later dies were produced through a process of copying earlier coin images, with a resulting loss of accuracy. Kleiner recognized that, ideally, "it would be possible by means of a die study to determine the exact sequence of production […] and identify with certainty the first dies to be cut, i.e., the master designs modeled on the arch itself, from which all the later dies were copied."[20] Kleiner went on to argue that such a study is not possible, "because the surviving coins represent only a tiny fraction of the original production and not all combinations of obverse and reverse die can be documented." This study shows that even if all combinations of dies cannot be documented, it is still possible for such an analysis to yield useful results.

In the absence of a complete die study, Kleiner's alternative approach was to conduct a die study of the arch *sestertii* by themselves and "to establish an approximate sequence of issues based on die linkage and die breakage in the arch series alone." To this he added criteria involving the legend, especially the abbreviation GERM for Germanicus (rather than GER), which MacDowall had already identified as indicative of the earliest obverse legend on coins bearing the arch. But Kleiner also added "the subjective criterion of style" as a further criterion, without elaboration.[21] The resulting sequence, argued Kleiner, "proves that what one might expect to be the case is, in fact, the case: the earliest dies are, in general, more carefully cut and more detailed than the later dies." Details like the keystone or small images of Roman soldiers atop the arch are included in the earlier dies, but not on later ones or on dies produced at Lugdunum. This method, while innovative and well-received at the time, involved the danger of circularity, since it does not rely entirely on the independent identification of the earliest dies and since it also incorporated subjective (and not clearly explained) criteria.[22]

The opportunity presented by this study of Nero's Issue IV *sestertii* is that it encompasses a study of coins of all types struck in that issue, not just those representing the building. The results have allowed us to identify the first dies cut for this new issue. This makes it possible to test Kleiner's hypothesis that the most detailed dies are those that were produced first. We do not propose a reconstruction of the temple based on this evidence, rather we focus on what it

20. This and following quotes from Kleiner 1985, 99.
21. Kleiner 1985, 100.
22. Boschung (1989, 188) called Kleiner's numismatic study "vorbildlich."

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can reveal about Kleiner's theories from a methodological perspective.[23] If our interpretation of the die links in figure 1 is correct, these dies represent the earliest dies used in the mint in Issue IV, presumably in December of the year 64 CE. These include the earliest dies depicting the Temple of Janus along with the three variants of the Roma type (H, J, and K dies). This group contains three Janus Temple dies: F20, F34, and F51. On these earliest dies, the façade of the Temple of Janus is narrow and tall. Two columns flank the central doorway. These columns appear to be square in section, rather than round, more like pilasters than columns. Although some later dies show curling lines atop the columns, these early dies show very simple capitals, perhaps Tuscan or Doric.[24] A single arch, approximately as wide as the columns, springs from the column capitals and spans the area above the door. Above this is a cornice and above that an attic surmounted by another cornice. The door consists of two tall leaves, each composed of three panels of unequal dimensions. The upper and lower panels are adorned with a single boss, while the central panel features two bosses. A large circular handle appears to be suspended from the upper boss in the central panel. There is no clear indication of a threshold, nor, for that matter, any form of stylobate or other platform below the main structure of the temple. On the side of the temple, the space filling the area between the columns is occupied in its lower two-thirds by three rows of block-like shapes. On all the temple dies in figure 1, these blocks are rendered using multiple lines, indicating that they are not flat surfaces joining at their edges, but instead that either there are wide spaces between the blocks where they join, or that the edges of the blocks themselves are contoured or equipped with moldings. Above this are windows, or a single large open space covered by a grid of bars, in three rows. A long horizontal architrave spans the space above the window(s).

Comparison of the Temple of Janus dies in this earliest group with the larger number of later dies reveals some patterns in the development of the design as production of Issue IV continued. At the beginning of the sequence, the width of the side of the temple is always greater than the doorframe. However, on some

23. Müller 1943 is the only comprehensive attempt to reconstruct the original appearance of the temple.

24. Müller (1943) argued, based on an Etruscan urn similar in appearance to the coin images, that the column capitals on the Temple of Janus were Etruscan capitals with volutes. Although similar capitals do appear on some coin dies, the evidence of the die analysis shows that these are not among the earliest dies to be produced. Similarly, Müller's theory that the architrave and attic were adorned with a scroll pattern and palmettes must be rejected on the basis of this coin evidence: in fact, these details are entirely absent on the early temple dies and appear to be restricted to coins produced not at Rome but rather at Lugdunum.

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later dies, the dimensions of the doorframe begin to become greater than the side of the temple. Furthermore, the overall dimensions of the temple become shorter and wider. This parallels the development of the Arch of Nero as studied by Kleiner, whose earliest dies show a relatively tall and narrow structure, in comparison to the squat arch on later issues. The details of the temple, more specifically those on the doorframe, slowly become simplified. The doors at the beginning of the sequence each have a round door handle that is attached to a circular protrusion; however, the end of the sequence mostly consists of just a round door handle. Again, the more detailed dies belong to the earlier part of the issue.

The windows present some problems of interpretation. One of the earliest dies (F20) shows a tall, narrow temple with three rows of windows on the side; the other two dies show two rows of windows. The characteristics of a tall and narrow temple with three rows of windows are also shared by the two Janus Temple dies (F1 and F13) linked to the single dated obverse die a1 (fig. 2), suggesting that this small die cluster also belongs here at the beginning of Issue IV. This, in turn, may indicate that the version closest to the original appearance of the temple is the one with three rows of windows, which is to say, a more detailed version. Later dies also show that the number of openings in the window area decreases, down to a common standard of two rows of five openings; this suggests that the version with three rows of windows is closer to the original design for the coin type. At the same time, it appears that the two-row version came into being very close to the beginning of the production sequence. This shows that one cannot rely simply on a standard of "most detailed" in identifying probable early dies, but that one must ideally adduce other evidence, for example, that of die links.

CONCLUSIONS

Sestertii struck for Nero in 64/65 CE were conceived as a single coherent issue with two main iconographic components: Roma (in three variants) and the Temple of Janus. The die links documented in this study enable us to reconstruct the sequence of production throughout the year, and from that to draw two important conclusions. Initial production of *sestertii*, as documented by die links, included all four types (three Roma, one temple). However, soon only one Roma type (with *parazonium*) continued to be struck, along with the temple. This indicates that, in this year at least, the mint did not follow the more ambitious iconographic program with which it began production. Nonetheless, the overall effect of the issue would have remained the same, presenting the viewer

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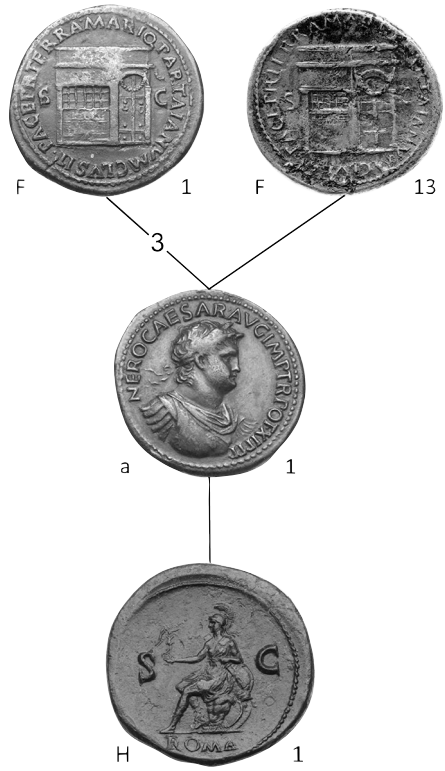


Figure 2. Early Issue IV die cluster including dated *sestertius* die a1 (TR POT XI).

with images of Roma and the Temple of Janus together with its accompanying inscription advertising the return of peace and Nero's role in it. The estimated reverse die counts also allow us to evaluate the role played by the temple type in this issue. With a count of somewhat more than two-thirds as many dies as those cut for the Roma types (514 estimated dies), it appears that the temple type (367 estimated dies) was considered roughly equal to Roma in the initial plan.

The second main conclusion of this study is that the pattern of die links allows us to identify with a high degree of confidence the earliest dies produced depicting the Temple of Janus. These are the dies used to strike coins alongside all three Roma variants, which are further singled out as having been found closely linked to one another in a single group, in contrast to the remaining dies of the issue. This shows that Kleiner's theory of the earliest dies being the most

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detailed and reliable for the reconstruction of the appearance of a building is probably correct in many respects (here, especially the details of the doors), but also that inconsistencies (three versus two rows of windows) can appear even in the earliest dies cut for an architectural type.

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DIE CATALOGUE FOR FIGURES 1 AND 2

This abridged die catalogue is excerpted from the complete die catalogue of Nero's Issue IV *sestertii*. It is intended only to document the links in figures 1 and 2. The identifying numbers provided for coins from collections are those used in *OCRE*. For coins from auction houses, the final number is the lot number.

Obverse Types

a NERO CAESAR AVG IMP TR POT XI PPP (Nero, right, laurel, cuirass)
b NERO CLAVD CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP (Nero, right, laurel, [sometimes] with aegis)
c NERO CLAVD CAESAR AVG GER PM TRP IMP PP (Nero, left, laurel)

Reverse Types

F Temple of Janus, door right
H Roma holding Victory and *parazonium*
J Roma holding Victory and shield
K Roma holding Victory and spear

CATALOGUE

F1	a1	a. Berlin 1820638. b. British Museum 1900,0402.10. c. Lanz (22 Nov 1999) 249
F13	a1	a. British Museum 9916.
F20	b23	a. Künker (2 Oct 2015) 8616.
F34	b26	a. Hirsch (3 Nov 2004) 727 = Hirsch (23 Apr 2003) 619.
F51	c8	a. CNG (24 Sep 2014) 458 = CNG (2 Nov 2011) 376.
H1	a1	a. Boston MFA 59.181.
H9	b23	a. British Museum 9962.
H4	b23	a. Hirsch (15 May 2019) 231 = NAC (26 May 2014) 2134.
	b52	a. Tauler and Fau (24 Nov 2020) 98.
H24	b52	a. Gemini (11 Jan 2015) 344 = CNG (1 Jul 2015) 505.
H45	b23	a. Inumis (20 Mar 2009) 169.
J1	b23	a. Bowers (12 Jan 2013) 6073. b. Künker (16 Mar 2007) 8883. c. Meister & Sonntag (1 Oct 2008) 293.
	b78	a. Nomisma (28 Apr 2018) 3189 = Nomisma (11 Nov 2018) 3078.

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J2	b26	a. CNG (6 Apr 2016) 407.
	b43	a. CNG (4 Dec 1996) 1395.
		b. Elsen (12 Mar 2016) 138.
		c. Lanz (22 May 2006) 274.
	c8	a. Künker (7 Oct 2019) 1326.
J5	b43	a. Noble (30 Jul 2019) 4754 = CNG (7 Mar 2012) 81.
K1	b23	a. Inasta (9 Dec 2019) 269 = Bertolami (26 Apr 2017) 415 = CNG (31 Jan 2007) 315 = CNG (23 Jul 2003) 97.
	b26	a. Heritage Auctions Europe (21 May 2014) 212.
K2	b26	a. NAC (12 May 2005) 1923.
K3	b78	a. CNG (24 Mar 2021) 425 = CNG (8 Nov 2017) 564.
K10	b23	a. British Museum 9955.
K11	b78	a. British Museum 9956.
K13	b26	a. Göttingen 184540.

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